film on his roster made him exert his financial and networking muscle to present Ritesh Batra's bittersweet *The Lunchbox* (2013), an international sleeper hit. No character could be less romantically appealing than Saajan Fernandes, the film's curmudgeonly misanthrope; yet the aura of pent-up longing is built up by Irrfan inhabiting a character who is not old "but feels old". Batra gives examples of Irrfan's investment in script and costume—"Oh, this costume is not right and we should not shoot till we get it right." So, plans would be changed. At other times, he would be reading specific books to help him establish the film's tone and pace—for instance, Murakami's *Norwegian Wood*.

It was a measure of his confidence and universal acceptance that Irrfan's last years while battling endocrine cancer were devoted to two rumbustious comedies on that most obsessive of all Indian questions—how, and where, to find an education. With *Hindi Medium* (2017), he joined the '100-crore club'—the actor who could 'open' a Friday. It was followed by *Angrezi Medium* (2020), not a sequel.

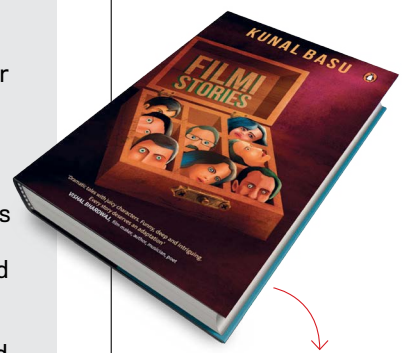
Gupta underscores Irrfan's value as a disruptor in a controlled mainstream industry where the box office creates and discards stars. Perhaps his more enduring legacy was to pass the torch to a roll call of actors such as Ayushmann Khurrana, Rajkummar Rao, Vicky Kaushal, Pankaj Tripathi and Jaideep Ahlawat, who challenge the hegemony in films and streaming networks. ■

Sunil Sethi

The Plots Thicken

Strap on your seatbelt, because **Kunal Basu**'s *Filmi Stories* is a racy and rollicking read

Filmi Stories was writer Kunal Basu's pandemic project. After all, what better way for a writer to allay the effects of cabin fever than to take up the pen. "In the fleeting spring of 2021, as the world was reeling from the pandemic, I thought to write a few stories to drive out the despair that was filling me up like smoke in a chimney stack," says Basu in the 'Prologue' to this short story collection. He dipped into his Havana cigar box, where he kept hastily scribbled notes brimming with story ideas, but that didn't do the trick. Inspiration manifested in unexpected and dramatic ways—during a game of Monopoly in one case—not unlike the stories themselves.



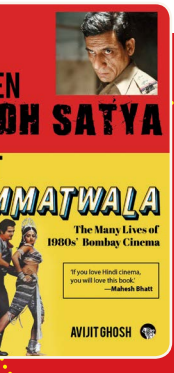
FILMI STORIES
by Kunal Basu
PENGUIN VINTAGE
₹499; 272 pages

The eight stories in this collection have wild premises and plotlines. A corpse in a well-tailored suit is found on a beach in one. In another, the protagonist finds himself to be the sole passenger on an airplane flying from one deserted airport to another. Yup, very filmi. In the hands of a skilled storyteller with a fecund imagination like Basu, seemingly incongruous matter aligns harmoniously on the page, albeit with a dark twist.

Take the first story—'OK TATA'—for instance, where Jaggi the trucker sets out to kill his wife's alleged lover. The lives of the truckers are drawn in striking detail, from the trucker-helper dynamic to the eateries that cater exclusively to them, the clear nights under the stars, the policemen "always thirsty for bribes", the dance bars they frequent (which is where Jaggi met his wife Jhimli) and *bhukki*, "the opium powder that was a staple among truckers". Basu writes, "You swallowed *bhukki* to stop feeling sad, stop feeling angry, stop missing home, stop feeling anything." The denouement is as unexpected as it gets, and only Basu could have nailed it.

Basu defines the premise of the collection thus: "I have always considered film and fiction to be ungainly cousins, each trying its best to cover up the imperfection of the other. Might there be a third cousin? A kinder one..." *Filmi Stories* is the answer to that question. ■

Amit Dixit



WHEN ARDH SATYA MET HIMMATWALA: The Many Lives of 1980s' Bombay Cinema
by Avijit Ghosh
SPEAKING TIGER
₹599; 392 pages

context, box-office statistics and personal reminiscence (the decade coincided with his teens and early twenties, a crucial time for any moviegoer). While discussing many important films of the time, he also describes the sideshows that affected filmmaking, distribution and the ways in which we consumed movies: for instance, the arrival of the video-cassette recorder (and its inevitable adjunct, video piracy); or the direct-to-store 'video features' produced by Nari Hira that briefly provided an alternate viewing experience. One chapter also discusses the impact of the almost-forgotten 1986 film-industry strike, and how it intersected with the political careers of stars like Sunil Dutt and Amitabh Bachchan.

The more formulaic chapters—though also the ones that may most appeal to a general readership—contain short write-ups about important personalities, from the 'art' stars mentioned above to star sons like Sunny Deol and Kumar Gaurav to filmmakers like Rahul Rawail and Subhash Ghai. This is Wikipedia-level information that can easily be found elsewhere, not particularly analytical or personal, often simply devolving into lists of films. But at its best, when it takes a wider view to show us that the 1980s indeed contained multitudes, and that the decade would have far-reaching effects on Hindi cinema, *When Ardh Satya Met Himmatwala* lives up to its amusing title. ■

Jai Arjun Singh